

erally. Belavadi, whose firm has tied up with Branson's Virgin Galactic to offer people luxury trips to space, says, "Preparing for this journey necessitates adopting a mindset focussed on envisioning and accomplishing the seemingly impossible. It requires embracing a willingness to take calculated risks, an unwavering commitment to a 'can-do' attitude, and above all, maintaining robust physical and mental well-being."

Sample this: a trip to the ISS would require you to go through several medical tests before your physical training starts to make sure that nothing can go wrong while you're up in space or on your way there. This hurdle passed, and travellers are expected to go through a high-G (high levels of acceleration) centrifuge run that goes up to 8Gs, which acclimatises them to the sensation of accelerating to massive speeds when the spaceship lifts off.

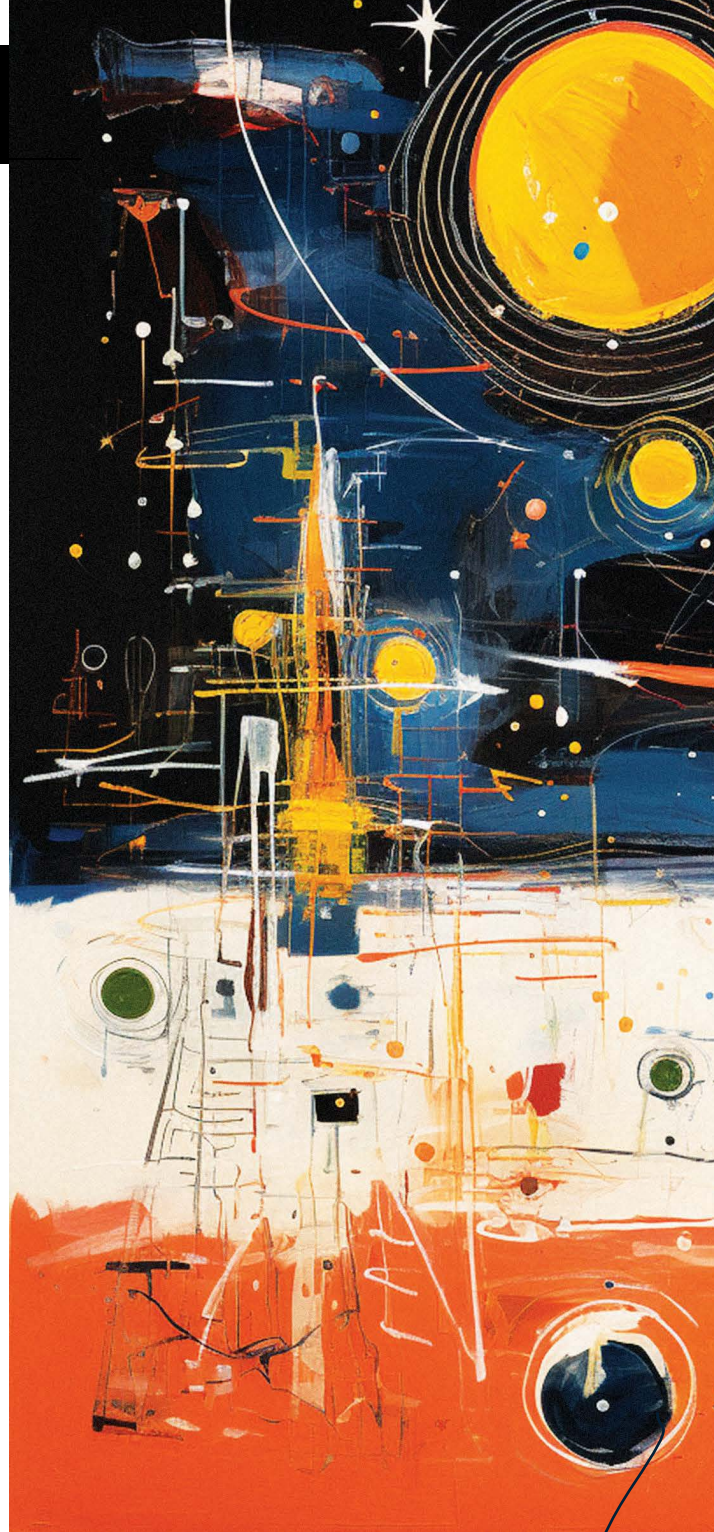
Another interesting aspect of the training is the simulated effect of high altitudes in a hypobaric chamber (altitude chamber). This prepares a passenger for the loss of pressure that occurs in a spacecraft in motion.

"Achieving this dream involves a combination of ambition, good health, risk-taking, and financial resources. While these elements may seem straightforward individually, finding them in a single person can be quite challenging. Yet, that's the essence of it all," says Belavadi. Separately, the training required for spaceflights that take you into low-earth orbit can be a little less daunting but no less exciting, as the prize is literally a trip to space. The training also includes preparations like zero-gravity acclimatisation and normal weight training, among other things.

While the thrill of going to space is surely unmatched, it does require material affluence here on earth to fund such a sojourn. As for aspiring passengers here in India, Belavadi says the cost could work out to anywhere between \$500,000 and \$4 million, depending on the provider, specific opportunities, considerations, and additional associated expenses. But he does say that a trip to space would become as easy and economical as booking a long-haul first-class air ticket within the next five to 10 years. So, who should hitch a ride to space?

AN EXCLUSIVE EXPERIENCE

With three of the biggest global entrepreneurs pushing the cause of civilian space travel, industry observers say the time is not far when we will see people casually booking a space ride for a unique date or a



thrilling adventure, much like they currently do with private jets. "Space travel, much like the early days of commercial air travel, is likely to remain exclusive to a select few initially, gradually becoming a prominent facet of experiential journeys," says Belavadi.

He adds that those people with greater purchasing power or disposable income who value exclusive